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Zande theology

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Document Type: Book Chapter

Original Page: 21-23(2)

Culture (OWC): [Azande \(F007\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Central Africa

Field Date: 1926-1929

Coverage Date: 1926-1929

Place Coverage: Sudan

Section Title(S): Untitled Section

The women finally gathered together in a homestead at the edge of the settlement in which I lived and I hurried out to meet them as soon as I heard that they were there. Only women took part in the ceremony and the few men who, like myself, were onlookers, happened to live nearby and could hardly have avoided being spectators. On the whole they seemed to regard the antics of the women as a joke. These were dancing wildly in the centre of the homestead and one of them was now beating the drum. They waved leaves of food plants in their hands and beat the ground with sticks singing various songs, usually consisting of a single sentence....

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No translations can be offered for the first two lines other than the explanations suggested below of the words maziga and Baati. The third line might be translated 'Mbori has taken his son from me, Mbori ooo,' and the fourth line as 'My father has died Mbori alas, alas, death, we have departed.' During the singing and dancing the leading ghost-diviner became possessed with ghosts and twitched and trembled and shook as though she had convulsions. Some of the other women beat her on the back and poked their fingers into her ears. They must have danced [23] thus for half an hour when, preceded by the leading ghost-diviner, they rushed off at the double along a path to a stream singing....

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On arrival at the stream head they continued to sing for a while and to beat the drum.  21-23(3) Finally they cleared an open space on the floor of a shallow chasm at the head of the stream. At this point the leading ghost-diviner swooned in convulsions, and the ceremony came to a conclusion. The

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women oiled their bodies in the bush and made themselves presentable before returning to their homesteads. I was told that on the following morning the ghost-diviners ate special medicines--ghost medicines--known only to them. The country was laid under a kind of general interdict against eating manioc leaves and the oil-bearing plant ndakö (*Hyptis Spicigera*-Sch.), because the senior ghost-diviner had been given an order to this effect by the Supreme Being in a dream and her dream had been confirmed by Gangura's poison oracle."

Magicians And
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